Drainage of Africa

1. River Nile

The Nile is the longest river in the world with a length of 6650 km. It has two main tributaries. They are the White Nile, which originates from Burundi, and the Blue Nile, which originates from Ethiopia. These two join and form the Nile River at Khartoum, in Sudan. It flows towards northward and drains into the Mediterranean-sea. Nile is known as the "**Father of African Rivers**".



The country Egypt is called the "**Gift of the Nile**" as it is the lifeline of the Egypt. Without Nile the Egypt would have been a desert.

ACTIVITY

On the outline map of Africa draw the courses of main rivers and name them.

2. River Congo or Zaire

Congo is the second largest river of Africa after Nile. Its length is about 4700km. Congo rises in the highlands of North Eastern Zambia between lakes Tanganyika and Nyasa. It flows through West Central Africa and drains into the Atlantic Ocean.

3. River Niger

Niger is one of the major rivers in West Africa and rises from the highlands of Guinea. It flows for about 4184 km and finally drains into the Gulf of Guinea on the Atlantic Ocean.

4. River Zambezi

The Zambezi River is the fourth longest in Africa. It rises in the north western Zambia. It is about 2574 km long and drains into the Indian ocean.The world famous waterfall 'Victoria' is formed by this river at the height of 108 meters. It is called the Southern Africa's "**River of Life**".

River Limpopo and river Orange are the other important rivers of Africa.

Climate

Africa is divided into six major climatic zones. They are:

1. **Arid and semi-arid climate:** Northern Africa and Southern Africa have this climate. Rainfall is scanty in this part.
2. **Tropical savanna climate:** It is found from 10^0-20^0 latitudes on either side of the equator. It is a tropical wet and dry climate.
3. **Equatorial climate:** It is found in the equatorial region covering the Congo River basin and east African highlands. Temperature and rainfall are high all the year round in this region
4. **Temperate climate:** It prevails in southern tip of South Africa. Since this part is located on the coast, the climate of this region is equable.
5. **Mediterranean climate:** It is found in the north-western and south western tips of Africa. These regions get rainfall in winters while in summers it is hot and dry.
6. **Tropical Monsoon climate:** It is found in the eastern shore of Africa. Summers are hot with monsoon winds bringing good rainfall while winters are cool and dry.

FACT

Tropical deserts are located between 20° and 30° north and south of the equator on the western margin of the continents. The deserts lie in the belt of the trade winds which blow from northeast in the northern hemisphere and southeast in the southern hemisphere. Therefore, the general direction of the trade winds is from east to west. These winds shed their moisture on the eastern margins of the continents and by the time they reach the west, they lose their moisture.

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